Las Vegas

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/41647776.

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Mature

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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Las Vegas

by SharkAria

Summary

It's finally time for Uncle Skeletor and Castaspella's New Year's Elvis-themed wedding extravaganza in glitzy Las Vegas, Nevada! Seems like the perfect place for Prime to show Glimmer all the ways he's grown since she dumped him-- but all these annoying people keep getting in the way of his mission.

Ensemble cast. Some of these characters have strayed pretty far from canon, but I can't help falling in love with them. The final planned entry for my series, 1998.

Notes

This story is full of forgiveness. Maybe earned, maybe not, but I'm tired of conflict and ready for love! Also, this story is full of Elvis because the early 2000s had an enormous resurgence of the King and also because that's just what I felt like doing.

I've taken these characters pretty far from their original canon forms, but I hope you'll still find the story compelling. Thank you for following this series over the course of many years!

Chapter 1

Viva Las Vegas

"Your flowers are falling!"

Prime stops scanning the gaudy reception hall for one particular wedding guest and glances down to Entrapta, yelling over the Elvis cover band.

She's taller than usual in her platform saddle shoes, but still so short that the crown of her head doesn't reach the top of Prime's shoulder. She pulls a hairpin from her complicated double-bun updo and reaches toward his boutonniere.

He suppresses the deep-seated instinct to shove her away, which he supposes is an improvement over the way he used to react to his sister-in-law, and instead reaches into the pocket of his tux trousers. "Try these," he says, handing her a few safety pins.

She grins guilessly. "You're getting much better at preparing for alternative scenarios! California has done you good in that way."

"The West Coast has given me the opportunity to hone my skills." And the opportunity to make money -- absurd gobs of money; vast, seemingly endless tranches of money. Prime has surprised even himself with his speed in converting Entrapta and Hordak's cutting-edge technologies into a ridiculously profitable company with hundreds of employees. Crypto Castle LLC's earnings are already on track to eclipse the Horde fortune; Prime, his brother, and his sister-in-law are now multimillionaires many times over. Silicon Valley venture capitalists and Manhattan legacy investment firms alike are stumbling over each other to get in on the action. *Wired Magazine* was calling Entrapta 'the Chicana Steve Jobs' until Prime got the lawyers to send a cease and desist on the grounds that Apple wasn't nearly as fast as Entrapta at pumping out revolutionary inventions.

But there's a price for fame and fortune. "Unfortunately, Fresno isn't Boston," Prime says.

And Boston is where *she* still lives.

Entrapta blinks, but she doesn't reply. She stabs the pin through the ostentatious lime green lily that Casta insisted the grooms' attendants wear for the big day.

"Careful," Prime admonishes. He can't have a stupid green stain on his white dinner jacket lapel; not tonight, when he has to look his best for *her.*

"Almost got it," Entrapta says, jabbing another pin into place.

He looks down at Entrapta's scalp; she's been growing out her black roots since before her own city hall ceremony about a year ago; now only the braided buns remain violet. How is it possible that *Entrapta* has helped him get here -- get a last chance with everyone?

It makes absolutely no sense.

Prime furrows his brows. "Why do you keep helping me, Entrapta?"

"Because your flowers keep falling off." Entrapta quirks her head and examines her handiwork.

Prime sighs. "I'm not talking about the flowers," he says.

Entrapta looks up and meets Prime's eye. "What do you mean, then?"

"You brought me in to run the finances for your business. Convinced me to take up Uncle Skeletor's offer to serve as his Best Man tonight." Prime gazes up at the gilded ceiling. "You got Hordak to speak to me again."

Entrapta's thin-tweezed brows furrow. She bites her lip, then shrugs. "I'm good at tech. As good as you are with money." She says it without a hint of a boast, just a statement of fact as she unselfconsciously smoothes down her purple pencil skirt. "But relationships don't come as easily. For either of us, I think."

An old, familiar flame of anger burns, but Prime swallows the insult on his tongue.

"That's why." Entrapta pats Prime's lapel. "I know what it's like to need help with this stuff."

Obviously Entrapta is talking about Prime's slowly mending connection with Hordak, but that's not the relationship that springs into Prime's mind. Prime nods and adjusts his collar. "Looks like you fixed it."

Entrapta grins. "Yep. You're ready to tear it up. Save me a dance!" she calls as she flits away.

Prime doesn't bother to answer. There's only one woman he wants to dance with tonight, and it's not his sister-in-law.

Maybe, just maybe, she'll want to do the same.

A Little Less Conversation

Prime heads toward the bar. He barely avoids sartorial disaster by sidestepping two stout blurs streaking past -- Casta's grandsons, twin boys with dark curly hair, matching purple bow-ties, and goblets of pink, sloshing fruit punch. "Watch where you're going," Prime calls, but there's little fire in his words; in fact, it seems like a good idea to follow them just in case *she's* somewhere near her extended family.

Before he can follow them, there's a tap on Prime's shoulder.

"Prime! I owe you a drink!" Bow says with a gleeful smile.

Prime clenches his teeth. Hopefully he can give the overly-enthusiastic engineer the brush off. “Surely you don’t owe me a thing. And the bar is hosted.”

“Alright then, just *share* a drink with me. At least until my boyfriend returns from the bathroom.” Bow gets the bartender’s attention and orders the ‘Jailhouse on the Rocks,’ one of several available Elvis-themed signature cocktails. "And of *course* I owe you. A year ago I was stuck doing water treatment projects for Boston Public Works. Now I have a California condo with palm trees and a pool, and I’m the head of Crypto’s Innovation Unit.”

“I didn’t have anything to do with that,” Prime lies.

“Come on, share a drink with me."

“Really, I don’t --”

“Oh, sorry. I heard that you don’t usually drink alco --” Bow breaks off with a nervous laugh. There’s only one person he would have heard that from.

Prime keeps his face neutral. Maybe there’s still hope. Maybe he can get some information. "Club soda with a lime," he tells the bartender.

“Uh -- anyway. How do you like my suit?” Bow stutters, obviously trying to cover the awkwardness.

Prime looks Bow up and down. The powder blue tux and ruffled shirt should, by the laws of the universe, be hideous, but somehow it manages to complement Bow’s warm dark skin tone and give him a sophisticated, retro vibe. “Not my style,” Prime says, because Bow doesn’t need to know that he looks good. “But it fits the wedding theme.”

Bow smiles. “Thanks. And -- thanks for the job, like I’ve been trying to say. Entrapta said *you* recommended me, not Catra, like I always assumed.”

Prime had pushed Entrapta to recruit Bow so that he'd leave Boston and stay away from the woman who'd once pined after him, not because Prime had any idea whether Bow was good at his job. In any case, the gambit worked; Bow happily moved across the country and away from *her,* and fortunately, he turned out to be quite competent. "You've expanded our range of profitable products," Prime says. "You've been a worthwhile hire."

"Was that a compliment?" Bow asks earnestly. " I heard you don't give those out easily."

"You've *heard* quite a bit about me," Prime sneers. "From our mutual -- colleague, I assume?" *Come on, idiot, say something about* her.

Bow raises an eyebrow at the word 'colleague.'

Prime sips the club soda and clears his throat. "She RSVPed yes --" without a plus one -- "but I didn't see her in the audience at the ceremony. But surely she's here, right?" Shit, that sounded desperate. "I mean -- she'd come for her aunt. Obviously."

"She's here," Bow replies hesitantly. He looks down into his drink and stirs it with the swizzle stick. "She's asked about you, once or twice, when I call home. I think you're still on her mind."

It's all Prime needs to hear. He chugs the club soda and slams the glass on the bar. "Keep making us money, Bow." And with that, he heads toward the dance floor.

Suspicious Minds

He doesn't get far.

"Well, well. If it isn't my former underling, looking dashing as always."

"Angella." Prime clenches his teeth into a grimace.

"California is clearly treating you well. You look like an aristocratic surfer with those broad shoulders and all that long blond hair."

"Business norms are more relaxed on the West Coast. And you -- you look radiant." Which, admittedly, is true. She's one of very few women he's met who's almost as tall as he is; though she must be in her sixties, her pale face is only lightly lined with age, and she wears her mostly-strawberry blonde hair down her back. Her full skirted, tea-length gown and glittering jewels gives her the appearance of a rich, bohemian fairy godmother.

Prime points to the dress. "Vintage Chanel, I assume?"

"Ah, handsome *and* knowledgeable!" She beams, but there's a sharpness to her expression. "You know, I've always liked you, Prime. Even when you were trying, and failing, to undermine my leadership."

"It was just business, Angella," he replies smoothly.

"Just business. Of course." She smiles beatifically. "Speaking of which, I have a bit of that to discuss with you. Perhaps you know that D.T. brings an excellent, unique skill set to your old position, but they haven't yet learned to operate with your ruthless efficiency."

"I thought my ruthlessness was the problem," Prime answers. Hopefully he sounds bored.

"When you worked *for* me, it was a problem. But now, my clients are eager to invest in your brother and sister-in-law's company, where your aggression would have greater utility." Angella examines a ruby solitaire on her middle finger. "Also, we want to help you take Crypto Castle public."

Prime's eyes go wide as he mentally calculates the potential profit. But he knows better than to seem too interested. "There are benefits to keeping the company in family hands. You should know that, considering you bought *my* firm out from under me not so long ago."

Angella laughs. "We don't have much reason to trust one another, do we? But I know you want more than a garish ranch on the outskirts of Phoenix like your uncle. You seem more like the private spaceship entrepreneur type. You know that stock options would help you achieve your dreams." She flips her long hair over her shoulder. "Anyway, talk to Entrapta and Hordak. Get their views."

Prime shrugs noncommittally.

"You should know this proposal is my daughter's idea, though I'm fully on board."

Prime freezes. "I find that hard to believe."

"I understand. She was still green when the two of you worked together, but not anymore." Angella gives Prime a significant look. "In fact, her opinion holds great weight at Etherian Enterprises these days. Make sure you talk to her tonight."

"I will," he rasps.

At that moment, Angella's husband approaches and wraps a muscular arm around her waist. "Looking good tonight, wife," he says. His head only comes up to his wife's chin, and his graying hair is pulled back in a ponytail to reveal bright red cheeks over a salt-and-pepper beard. "Prime, has anyone ever told you that you're a dead ringer for Skeletor thirty years ago? Hard to believe your uncle used to have even more hair than you."

Prime runs a hand over his head nervously and makes a mental note to research hair growth products. "Congratulations on your successful election, Senator Moon."

"It's Senator-Elect until the swearing-in next week," he says, shooting a triumphant glance at Angella, then turning back to Prime. "Couldn't have done it without your uncle. To think ol' Skel came through for an IBEW guy like *me* after all those years he spent union busting." He grins. "I heard you had something to do with that."

"Uncle Skeletor respects all competent politicians, even those whose policy perspectives diverge from his own." Prime had urged Skeletor to dump a bunch of money into Micah's Senate campaign in the hope that *she* would be impressed. "In any case, I'm happy to help."

Perhaps Prime's efforts will pay off, after all.

The song about the cheater who likes pina coladas starts playing, and Micah grins at his wife. "Angella, honey. Gonna take your old man out for a spin on the dance floor or what?"

Angella looks down at her husband and smiles. "Excuse me, Prime. I know you won't forget about what I said."

"I won't," Prime promises.

He watches as the junior Senator-Elect of Massachusetts snuggles his face into his wealthy wife's bosom and leans in to the seventies soft rock. At least it's something other than Elvis.

Are you lonesome tonight?

She's not on the dance floor. She's not at the buffet. She's not near the 'Family History' wall, although some of the pictures catch Prime's eye and make him pause.

There's an image of a middle-aged Uncle Skeletor, all suited up in his mid-century modern office, smirking and cradling a rotary phone receiver against his ear; a blurry picture of Hordak, standing and scowling in front of his brick prep school dorm; a formal portrait of Prime, so much younger, wearing his commissioned officer's uniform. There's a snapshot of Catra's beautiful mother Teela as a fresh-faced, olive-skinned teenager on a balcony in pre-revolutionary Cuba before she married into the Horde family, and a photobooth set of pictures of Hordak and Prime's ice-blonde parents on the night of their engagement, showing off a diamond solitaire. There are several black-and-white photos of shopkeepers in front of Korean-lettered signs in

the Boston suburbs -- Micah's and Casta's elders, presumably -- and a pair of foppish, whey-faced Britons driving Aston Martins and Rolls Royces in the British countryside -- Angella's family, undoubtedly. And there's a faded picture of a chubby, short kid wearing a Madonna tutu -- could *that* be -- ?

He senses a familiar presence at his side. "What do you want," he grumbles.

"Oh, nothing, cousin of mine," Catra says, her tone silky sweet, her breath drenched with booze, her grooms' attendant dinner jacket already stained with what is probably shrimp cocktail sauce. "I just wanted to tell you something very *interesting* -- something *important* --"

Prime tilts his head to the side and glares down at her. The move used to make Catra quail with fear, but it's been years now since he's elicited more than an amused snort from her. "Speak."

Catra snorts, as expected. "It's just that --" She leans in close. " *A certain special someone* with pink hair and a Boston accent says that I wear this tux better than you do," she says, adjusting her collar.

"She's here?" Prime takes hold of Catra's shoulder. "Where? Tell me. Now."

Catra grins, the Cheshire cat personified. "He took the bait!" She screeches over her shoulder. "I told you. I *told you!* "

Prime follows her gaze. It's only Adora, her arms crossed over her slinky red dress. *Shit.*

"You owe me a song!" Catra screams at Adora, whatever the hell that means, and she skitters off in the direction of her longtime girlfriend. *Idiot* .

It's now or never

Prime checks his Rolex. It's nearly midnight, and still there's no sign of *her.*

He's searched everywhere. Either she's left, or she's purposely avoiding him.

Suddenly the music stops, and there's an ear-splitting screech of feedback. Prime covers his ears and turns toward the stage.

Casta's there, standing in front of the band and clutching the microphone. Her enormous bouffant hairdo is still in place, but the poofy veil is beginning to sag after the long day. Though her eyeliner is smudged, and her pancake makeup has begun to collect in the creases of her skin, her smile remains luminous. Uncle Skeletor soon joins her, his sharkskin tuxedo shining under the bright lights almost as much as his bald scalp. "I know, I know." Casta calls into the mic as she clasps her new husband's hand. "We already said our vows at the ceremony and toasted each other at dinner, so you don't want to hear from us anymore. We'll keep it short, I promise. Everyone ready to count down to the new year?"

The crowd roars in approval.

Uncle Skeletor drapes his long arm over his wife's shoulder and bends over to speak into the microphone. "Hurry up now. Grab the person you want to kiss and get ready! Ten, nine . . ."

Prime glances at his patent leather wingtips. It's pathetic, starting the new year like this, staring down at his shoes. *A loser.*

He looks up, just once more, across the chanting crowd.

There's a familiar sparkle on the other side of the dance floor.

Her hair is shorter, and now dyed a sweet pink, with a lavender undercut. Her face, framed by statement earrings, is softer, rounder; her lips are fuller. Her sequined dress is like a rainbow confetti disco ball, long sleeved; backless and revealing her angel

wing tattoos, with a short hem that shows off her incomparable thighs. She's teetering in a pair of pointy-toed, glittery heels.

"Six, five, four . . ."

She rolls the stem of the martini glass between her fingers, turns toward him. She meets his eyes.

Time stands still.

"Three, two, one . . ."

She smiles, just a little, and raises her drink in a silent toast, then presses the glass to her lips.

He swallows.

"Happy New Year!"

The band strikes up "Got a Lot o' Livin' to Do." All around Prime, couples kiss, hug, toast, and drink.

Prime returns her smile. He takes a step forward.

And then there's another cheer. Balloons cascade down from above -- purple and gold, lime green and silver -- in a seemingly endless downpour. *Fuck!*

It takes forever, but finally the waterfall ends.

And of course, of *course,* she's gone.

Always on my Mind

"Are you going to drink that?" Prime growls.

"This champagne? No. Someone gave it to me for the midnight toast and I only took a sip to be polite." Hordak, who was resting against a faux column, straightens up and stares at Prime. "But don't you hate alcohol even more than I do?"

"Just give it to me."

Hordak shrugs. "Fine. It's all yours." He holds out the champagne flute.

Prime snatches it away and knocks it back. The carbonation burns his esophagus, and his stomach revolts. He coughs and gags.

This won't work. As much as Prime wants to forget, he can't do it this way. "Nevermind. That's disgusting."

Hordak has the good sense, or perhaps just longstanding ingrained fear, not to say *I told you so.* "If you need some sort of distraction, it looks like you're about to get one." He folds his arms over his dinner jacket and jerks his chin in the direction of the stage.

Adora's up front, the mic in her hand. The band's pianist plays a familiar opening melody.

"This one is dedicated to a wonderful woman in my life, the very special Catra Horde," Adora says, and she clears throat loudly. *"Wise men say, only fools rush in . . ."*

She's even worse than Prime might have anticipated. He closes his eyes and rubs his temples. "This isn't the sort of distraction I need."

Hordak snorts. "Look at Catra."

Prime does. His cousin is on the dance floor down in front of Adora, drunkenly swaying off beat, with her hands clasped over her heart as she mouths the lyrics back to her girlfriend.

"Catra's really eating this shit up," Hordak says with a low laugh. He cracks a nervous-looking smile. "But I'm happy for her."

"Right." Prime heaves a great sigh and looks down at the champagne flute. *What a fucking waste of a night.* "Give Casta

and Uncle Skeletor my regards. I'm going up to my room."

"You shouldn't leave yet." Hordak looks past Prime, and the corner of his mouth twitches upward. "I'm off. I owe my wife a dance."

Prime spins around.

She's there beside him, up close. Impossible to look at. Impossible to turn away from.

"Hey, Prime," she says with a small smile.

"Glimmer," he whispers.

[one more chapter coming soon!]

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

One more chapter coming after this!

Can't help falling in love

"I'm surprised to see you drinking," Glimmer says with a snarky, sexy half-smile. "Don't you remember what happened the last time you did?"

"Oh, I remember," Prime says, clearing his throat. It's shocking how easily, how quickly he slips back into the low, casual register he always reserved for her alone. "I often think of that first night with you."

Glimmer's eyebrow twitches, but her smile doesn't falter. "I often think of the next morning. Your hangover was hard to forget."

Still a brat . Prime smirks. Flirtatious insults are familiar, welcome territory.

He steps forward, into Glimmer's space, and he breaks eye contact long enough to set the champagne flute on a nearby table. "The months afterward were hard to forget, too." He looks over Glimmer's head and takes note of Angella and Micah nearby, very obviously *not* watching their daughter's every move. "But right now I don't want to look back. I want to enjoy what's in front of me." His eyes travel from the crown of Glimmer's head to the tips of her pointy-toed pumps.

Glimmer rolls her eyes. "Your corny lines haven't changed."

"My lines might be corny, but they always worked on you. Before." *Will they work tonight?* he doesn't add.

Glimmer looks toward her parents, then down at her glittery shoes. She bites her lip and seems to wrestle with her thoughts.

Quick. Before she talks herself out of it.

"Let's dance," Prime hears himself saying over Adora's wailing. "For old time's sake."

"Hmm." This time, Glimmer doesn't smile, not exactly, but she doesn't frown either. *A good sign.* "I don't think we ever shared a dance in the old times."

Prime offers his hand to her. "For the new times, then."

She tilts her head and raises an eyebrow. "One dance." She allows him to lead her to the floor, then slides her hands up his white suit sleeves and rests them on his shoulders. "Maybe two."

He presses his palms to the small of her warm, exposed back and pulls her close. Memories crash through his mind as he leans down and inhales her scent. Her sharp, familiar hairspray blends with a new, musky aroma. "You've changed your perfume."

"Amongst other things." She allows him to send her through a slow twirl before returning to his embrace, with her body closer to his than before. "You've made changes, too. At least, it seems like you have."

The bassist kicks Adora off stage, and the band strikes up a soupy fifties doo-wop that brings all the old folks onto the dance floor.

"Do you like the changes I've made?" Prime asks, finally.

Glimmer looks up at him, and the stage lights sparkle in her eyes. "I like your long hair."

Warmth spreads through Prime's chest. Lower, too. "And?"

"And I like how you ended your quest for revenge against my family. Even after I dumped you."

It was a mutual decision springs immediately to Prime's tongue, but there's no reason to voice that lie. Not to Glimmer.

He opens his step and shuffles them both to the center of the dance floor.

"I *did* think about burning everything to the ground," he says after a while. *I could have succeeded,* something still insists, deep inside.

He quickly quashes that old, sick part of himself. But he doesn't manage to keep his words under complete control, because he finds himself confessing, "You were right. That I'd keep failing as long as I pursued only destruction. So when Entrapta -- when Hordak and Entrapta *both* gave me the chance to help them create something new --"

Prime looks over to his brother and sister-in-law swaying together. Hordak carefully avoids eye contact, but Entrapta shoots him a big thumbs up.

He steers Glimmer away from his relatives. "Anyway, it's a long story. But it turned out that making money was more satisfying than getting revenge."

Glimmer slides one hand down Prime's bicep and rests it on his chest, over his heart. "And if it hadn't worked out for you in California, you still could have gone back to burning everything to the ground."

"Exactly," Prime says with a snort. He takes a deep breath and registers the strange sensation of something small and hard dislodging itself from the space between his ribcage and his diaphragm, leaving only calm behind. "You understand me. You always have."

She's so short. It's the first thing he noticed about her at Catra's party, all those years ago.

"Would you --"

"Are you --"

"You first," Prime insists.

"What we were doing back then was bad. Sneaking around. Lying to our families, to each other. It was really screwed up." Glimmer bites her lip. "You know that, right?"

"I didn't before." He looks at the happy couples around him -- Adora dipping Catra with a sloshy smile; Hordak trying to contain his bouncy wife to a smaller section of the dance floor; Micah pressing his red face into Angella's generous cleavage; Skeletor clutching his bony, knuckly hand around Casta's slim waist. "Now I do." *Now I know how love looks.*

He stares down at Glimmer.

Oh. Shit.

Her painted brows are furrowed with concern. "Are you okay?"

Definitely not. "Of course." He forces himself to relax his jaw and blinks away whatever Glimmer must see in his eyes.

But there's a new feeling now, something welling up beside the terror that comes from finally admitting to himself that he's truly, entirely *in love* with Glimmer: hope. "I'll be in Boston next week to deal with some property transfers," he says, letting the hope carry him along. "Why don't we -- why don't you let me -- I'll take you out. Not -- like before. I'll take you on a real -- you know. A date." Jesus, he sounds like a fucking idiot. "If you want me to," he adds quietly, lamely.

"That's not what I want," she says quickly, coldly.

"Oh. Fine."

It's not fine. It's a worse fucking mess than when she left him the first time.

Sluggishly, painfully, Prime loosens his grip on Glimmer's waist. "Thank you for the dance. Have a -- a pleasant evening," he says,

his every word a knife to his own battered heart.

"Wait. I don't want a date next week." Glimmer digs her nails into Prime's sleeve. "I want something else."

He freezes where he stands. There's that stupid feeling of *hope* again.

She huffs lightly, frustratedly. Her cheeks darken, and she opens her mouth. "I want to go up to your room. Right now. I want you to remind me of what I've been missing. What I can't stop thinking about even after all this time. What finally seems like something with a future, now that you're not so -- evil." She gives him a surprisingly shy smile.

He swallows, returns her smile. "I can still be evil," he murmurs slowly, hoarsely.

Her eyes sparkle. "I'm counting on it."

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Burning Love

Prime grips Glimmer's waist hard and leans in for that first kiss, the one that promises a new beginning.

She turns her face.

"What's wrong?" he asks, low in her ear, and sexy sounding, hopefully.

She wrinkles her nose. "Literally every one of our relatives is here, and they're all watching us. Let's save this for someplace private."

It's true -- they're surrounded and outnumbered by family . He straightens up and offers his hand to her. "This way."

Without another glance at the rubberneckers, Prime leads Glimmer off the dance floor, through the reception hall doors, and onto the casino floor.

His heart pounding and his hopes soaring, he winds through the maze of slot machines, past the craps tables, beyond the shiny blue 2004 Cadillac DeVille, waxed and jacked up on a stage of mirrors with a promise for *one lucky winner.* He reaches the elevator bank and jabs the button desperately.

Mercifully, the doors slide open, and Prime pulls Glimmer in behind him. Surely he's drunk, as drunk as the night he met her, even though he's had nothing more than a single gulp of midnight champagne. She's smiling seductively up at him, with the lights sparkling in her eyes and cigarette smoke from the casino clinging

to her hair, and finally, *finally* he can lean down to give her that years' delayed kiss, and --

"Hold the lift!"

It's Entrapta. Of fucking *course.* It's always Entrapta.

Glimmer pushes Prime away, the anticipation in her expression souring to embarrassment.

No, it's not just Entrapta. It's the whole fucking Horde clan piling in -- Hordak, and Catra and Adora, and even Glimmer's parents Angella Bright and Senator-Elect Micah Moon, all of them reeking of wilting wedding boutonnieres and expensive alcohol and shoving Prime to the back, where he can't reach over to push the button for his floor. Glimmer's spike heel stabs him painfully as she accidentally steps on his foot, and that's when Uncle Skeletor elbows in, followed by the bride herself, Castaspella. Her voluminous skirts force all the elevator occupants to flatten themselves against the walls.

Prime watches in dismay as Castaspella slams her silk-gloved fist against the button for the rooftop balcony and grins guilelessly at Glimmer, then at Prime. "Oh, I'm so happy we're all together tonight. They better not have started the fireworks without us."

"Fireworks?" Prime says, confused. It's hard to think amidst the cloud of competing perfumes. "We're not --"

"I'm so excited, Aunt Casta," Glimmer cuts in. "Can't wait to celebrate with the whole family."

The elevator doors open, and everyone spills out onto the vestibule leading to the grand rooftop. A spray of lime green and purple zings past and explodes in front of them.

Entrapta bounces forward. "Hurry, they're starting!" The wedding party follows her to the balcony.

Prime hangs back and grabs Glimmer's shoulder. "Let's go."

Her lips twitch, and she looks a little regretful, but not sad, exactly. She reaches over and places her palm over his hand. "Surely we owe them five more minutes of our time."

He clenches his teeth, but he follows Glimmer out to the railing, where it's surprisingly cold, with the wind blowing and the cloudy night sky reflecting the lights of the Vegas strip below. The Horde extended family is all lined up for the show, and now Castaspella's many relatives have arrived, too. They're all *ooh* ing and *aah* ing at the spectacle. Castaspella takes Glimmer's plump hand in her bony one, and aunt and niece gaze up in the air as if they've never seen fireworks before.

Prime would *not* put up with this shit for anyone except Glimmer.

And, Prime's impatience aside, he has to admit that Glimmer is *right* -- they do owe their family this much, at least. Besides, it's bad business sense to alienate the people in charge of the trust fund.

"Wow! It's hard to get that blue color right, but they did it!" Entrapta yells enthusiastically over the explosions, and Prime watches as Hordak steps back to let his wife squawk an utterly unfollowable explanation about oxidizers and fuel mixtures to Castaspella's entranced grandchildren.

Hordak is smiling to himself absently. He's watching Entrapta instead of the fireworks, and he looks utterly, rapturously in love.

Is that what Prime looks like when he's thinking of Glimmer?

He closes his eyes and shakes his head, and he looks over at his brother again.

This time, Hordak is watching. His smile falters, and his eyes dart over to Glimmer, then back to Prime. "She's --" He exhales and nods. "She's really great. I hope it works out this time."

"I don't need your well wishes," Prime sneers, but when Hordak visibly cringes, something shifts inside of him. *Goddammit.* "But

-- thanks." The word tastes bitter, and Hordak appears absolutely shocked.

That makes it a little sweeter, Prime supposes. "You certainly -- you and -- your wife --" he gestures helplessly toward Entrapta -- "You figured things out. Perhaps I will too. Someday." He gives his brother an uncertain smile. It feels awkward on his face.

Hordak smiles back, slowly at first. "Perhaps we all will, with each other. Someday. Like you said."

Before Prime has to reply, Entrapta pulls Hordak away.

Beyond his sister-in-law, there's Catra, who waggles her eyebrows as she is herding Adora toward the elevator. "*Primo* Prime!" she greets sloshily.

Adora guffaws beside her. "*Primo* Prime! 'Cousin Prime' in Spanish. I get it! You're so funny, honey. Hey, that rhymes!"

"Entrapta taught me," Catra brags, and she sways hard. Adora thrusts her arm out to catch her and just barely manages to keep them both upright.

Annoying drunk bitches, both of them.

"Remember, our room is next door to yours," Catra says to Prime in a slurring stage whisper. "So don't --"

"*Don't* finish that thought," Prime hisses, but Catra and Adora only laugh in his face and stumble off toward the elevators.

Which, frankly, is what Prime *wishes* he were doing. What in the hell is taking so long with the fucking fireworks?

Luckily, rain begins to fall. Castaspella's grandkids shriek, and Uncle Skeletor grumbles, and the rest of the guests just laugh as the last of the fireworks finale fizzles. The family heads indoors.

Soon, only Glimmer remains at the balcony rail, shivering and smiling in her short sequined dress, with her pink hair and glittery earrings whipping around her face.

Finally. "You're so fucking hot," Prime says over the howling wind.

She laughs. "I'm so fucking *cold,"* she says.

He steps forward, so close that his patent leather wingtips bump against the pointy toes of her stilettos. "I'll warm you up," he promises, and he wraps his arms around her luscious waist, and he leans down, and finally, *finally,* he gives her the kiss she deserves.

Power of My Love

"I missed that."

Prime grunts in agreement. He's lying naked on the hotel room floor, with the underside of the crumpled duvet scratching his bare back. Glimmer's makeup-smeared face is sticky against his neck, and he couldn't move if he wanted to.

"I missed *you,"* she adds, and it's obvious by her tone that she's embarrassed by her honesty. "Is that weird to say? It's weird, isn't it."

Prime smiles up at the ceiling. *Now* he's truly sated. "I won't tell anyone," he murmurs into her sweaty scalp.

She huffs, and her nails dig delightfully into his ribcage. "You're such a dick."

"Not the first time you've called me that."

"You missed me too," she says, an insistence, but the question lingers in her tone.

“More than anything.” Wait, was *that* weird? She said she *missed* him, not that she couldn't stop thinking about him. Not that she -- loved him.

Fuck it. He’s finished with concealing his desires to protect himself. It never worked, anyway.

“I want to be with you.” He shifts onto his side and pulls her against him. “I’ll move back to Boston to help you take Crypto Castle public. Entrapta and Hordak don’t need me in California full-time anymore.”

“That’s not going to work.”

Of course it’s not. Prime’s heart sinks. There’s always something in the way.

But incredibly, Glimmer just giggles, then embraces him. “It won’t work because I’m about to open a satellite office for Etherian Enterprises on the West Coast. So you have to stay. For me.”

He’s flying, or falling, or both. “Is that so,” he says, and it’s so freeing, not having to attempt to keep the sheer joy from his voice. “How convenient for both of us.”

“Yes, very convenient,” she replies, and she presses her lips to his.

“In that case, you should know I love you.” Prime almost gets it out without tripping over the words.

“I *know* ,” Glimmer replies, bratty, but her eyes gleam. And then, burning with sincerity, finally, once and for all, she says, “I love you too.”

Chapter End Notes

> This series took me 5 years to write and complete. I wrote it to connect with you. I hope you felt something!

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